Light to the Tavern

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The Third and the Ninth

CH16601-01

Street, Inside the City

The main street of Pèi City bustles with activity. Crowds throng the thoroughfare, the cries of vendors ring out, silks drape high over the streets, and piles of red pomegranates and walnuts rise in little towers on the market stalls.

A vendor pulls some freshly baked sesame buns out of the earthen oven behind him and lays them in a steaming stack on the stall counter. They exude an aromatic fragrance.

The little girl is huddled in front of the stall, her head barely peeking above the tabletop, her eyes unblinking, transfixed by the sesame buns.

Child Beggar: Aaahh, give me ...

Jiu: The little girl points into her open mouth with her finger.

Child Beggar: Feeling hungry ...

Citizen V: No money, no food. I'm running a business here. Now go away, shoo!

The little one, not understanding a word, casually snatches up a bun and devours it.

In recent days, the entire merchant hub has come to know this little beggar, whose origins remain unknown, as she wanders the streets all day and night.

Citizen V: Hey, beggar kid, give that back! You've been stealing buns from me for days!

Although the little one does not understand the purpose of these words, she can still sense the building rage behind them. She turns tail and flees, but before she can take more than a step, she collides head-on with two figures. The larger one catches her wrist.

Facao: Where are you going?

Facao: I've heard endless complaints about your stealing. You're not getting away.

Facao: Not this time. I'll get you locked away in prison. Then you'll never steal again!

Lizheng: I wouldn't have expected the Fǎcáo to deal with little girls ... I assume she committed a felony?

Facao: What you don't know, sir, is that this little beggar has been wandering the streets for days. No one knows where she came from. When she's thirsty, she drinks from the horse troughs, and when she's hungry, she steals food from the vendors.

Facao: She's quick as a stallion, too. No one could catch her when she entered the city. The patroller informed me a few days ago.

The little girl struggles, attempting to break free from the large hand that grips her.

Lǐzhèng leans down to scrutinize the young offender.

Lizheng: What's your name? Have you ever been to school ...? No, can you talk?

Child Beggar: I ... I need to stay in the city. The city needs a Xiángruì.

Lizheng: She can talk. Perhaps she's from a decent family, and something happened to them. Isn't it too harsh to put a little girl who has suffered so much into prison? Let's not make a fuss of it.

Facao: ...

Facao: Actually, I was thinking that prison would provide her with food and shelter. In the meantime, I could work on locating her parents.

Lizheng: My apologies. I suppose you are considerate under that harsh exterior of yours.

Lǐzhèng straightens up and strokes his beard. He appears to have already devised a plan for the beggar child's fate.

Yard, Tavern

After making their way down several streets, the three of them arrive at a tavern.

It is filled with patrons. Amidst the clinking of cups and the raising of toasts, idle chatter and laughter abound, creating a scene of merriment.

As they enter, the scent of liquor hits their nostrils. A graceful figure moves swiftly among the clientele, her presence as striking as it is efficient.

???: Welcome, Lǐzhèng, Fǎcáo! What brings you here?

???: Take a seat! You came just at the right time. I have some jars of Melon Brew that I haven't opened yet. I'm thinking that a couple of distinguished guests can do me a favor and have the first cup.

Citizen IV: Ms. Xǔ, you slippery little thing! If Lǐzhèng hadn't come today, when would you have told us about these new arrivals?

Citizen IV: Poor us, not even qualified to smell it!

Ms. Xǔ feigns annoyance, playfully scolding her patrons with a smile. They burst into laughter. As this moment passes, one patron stands to invite the two officials to take a seat.

Facao: No need. We're not here to drink.

Ms. Xu: You're not? Oh ... Well, everything's above board here. I've never even watered down a drink. Just ask my guests, they'll tell you!

Lizheng: Heh heh, don't worry, Ms. Xǔ. We're just here to check up on the stores.

Lizheng: Is everything going well with your tavern?

Ms. Xu: Yes, everything's fine. Some drinkers can get really talky, but that's all. No troublemakers, thanks to your management.

Ms. Xu: You know, most days, I have plenty of time to make the rice buns that I sell to the locals ...

Ms. Xu: But on liquor permit days, there are so many patrons in the tavern, and I have to serve all of them myself.

Lizheng: What a coincidence! I have just found you a helper.

Fǎcáo steps aside. He is about to introduce the child to Ms. Xǔ when he turns around to find that the little beggar has disappeared without a trace.

Facao: She was here just now! Where did she go?

After a thorough search, they find her curled up behind the counter. She refuses to answer any of their questions.

Ms. Xu: Lǐzhèng, don't tell me this is the new helper you were talking about.

Lizheng: Oh right, exactly.

Ms. Xu: There's no way I can take her. She looks more like a wild beast than a child, and she can't even speak fluently. She seems totally uncivilized! How could a girl like this help me?

Ms. Xu: Honestly. If she stays here, I'll have to spend just as much time taking care of her as I do the tavern! Lǐzhèng, you better not throw this hot potato to me.

Lizheng: You're right. She needs to be civilized. That's why I brought her here. Everyone in the city knows you're sharp as a tack. Why, you could teach a monkey to talk if you had to!

Lizheng: Besides, you're a kind person. No one is more suited to take care of a little girl than you.

Facao: We have no clue where we might find her parents. We can't just let her wander the streets.

Ms. Xu: What about the charity hall? I'm running a tavern here, not a school! Besides, she hasn't spoken a word since she got here! Is she some sort of dumb?

Upon hearing the word "dumb," the beggar girl stands up and dusts off her sleeves. She looks around the room, finally resting her gaze upon Ms. Xǔ.

Child Beggar: I'm not "dumb." My mommy called me Jiǔ.

Lizheng: Jiǔ. Does that mean you're the ninth in your family? Well, it's easy to remember.

Lizheng: See? She didn't say a word to us the whole way here, but she's already talking to you.

Ms. Xu: Three and nine ... What kind of fate could this be, if not a twisted one?

Somehow, the pure gaze and innocent, carefree demeanor of this little beggar makes her difficult to shoo away. Eventually, Ms. Xǔ's tone softens.

Ms. Xu: ... Jiǔ, huh? You've been begging for days, yet you still had the energy to run and hide in the tavern. You must be healthy.

Facao: She's quite the runner. Many adults couldn't keep up with her. Maybe she can help you run errands.

Ms. Xu: But, you see ... the extra food and clothing ...

Ms. Xu: I can barely earn enough money to feed myself.

Lǐzhèng wastes no time in instructing Fǎcáo to produce the settlement fee and hand it over to Ms. Xǔ.

The patrons gather, eager to see the amount, but Ms. Xǔ waves them off with a flick of her wrist. They laugh among themselves and return to downing their drinks.

Ms. Xu: Hmm ... This could be enough for now. But kids grow so fast, you know? I'll have to get her new clothes, new shoes every now and then ...

Lizheng: Haha! I've heard many rumors of Xǔ's silver tongue. You surely don't disappoint.

Lizheng: Alright, you've just won yourself the position of supplier to the Zhící. You'll be responsible for the ceremonial liquors during festivals.

Ms. Xu: Thank you so much, Lǐzhèng. I'll make the best liquor for the ceremonies.

Ms. Xu: And of course, I'll take good care of her.

With matters concluded, Lǐzhèng and Fǎcáo do not linger any longer. There are still many tasks awaiting them in the city, and so they take their leave.

The tavern quickly regains its earlier liveliness. On this precious liquor permit day, not a single moment must be wasted. Ms. Xǔ is still adjusting to the sudden arrival of her unexpected helper.

Ms. Xu: Follow me. You'll be staying in the tavern from now on. Starting tomorrow, you'll help me run the business. If you need anything, just tell me. Oh, and don't steal from others again.

Jiu: Water. I'm thirsty.

Ms. Xu: Water's in the yard. I'll get it for you.

Two officials walk down the street, their pace leisurely as they converse about the events of the day.

Facao: Lǐzhèng, why did you do all that to help that beggar girl?

Lizheng: When I first looked at that girl, I had the feeling that I'd seen her before. Besides, it would be a pity to have such a bright young thing roaming the streets.

Fǎcáo nods, habitually pressing down on the short sword at his waist and casting a final glance back at the tavern before turning into a side street.

Facao: I see.

Ms. Xu: You'll sleep here tonight. It used to be a utility room, but I've cleaned it, and the bed's new.

Ms. Xu: I heard that you slept on the street, so I guess you're not afraid of the dark.

Ms. Xu: I sleep in the room next to yours. Call me if you need anything.

Jiu: Yes. Sleep when you're sleepy.

Jiǔ rests her hands by her ear, tilts her head, and feigns the sound of slumber.

The child's innocent and carefree spirit softens Ms. Xǔ's heart, prompting her to leave a few tender instructions before departing.

Jiu: I'm alone now. Don't sleep on the street anymore.

Yielding to the moment, the child lies on the floor of the room. Tonight, there are no twinkling stars to accompany her, no cool breeze to caress her, only the faintly discernible beams overhead.

Wooden Doll: With a rustling sound, a troop of wooden dolls materializes out of thin air. They frolick and cavort on the bed, the ground, and on Jiǔ's clothes.

Wooden Dolls: ***chuckles* New place! Fun!**

Wooden Dolls: Liquor jars, liquor jars! Customers raising their cups!

The wooden dolls turn the day's sights into lyrical verses in an endless song.

One doll pushes through the others, leaping down from the bed to whisper into Jiǔ's ear.

Wooden Dolls: Personal feelings. You're having a lot.

Jiu: They're not personal feelings. You don't know anything.

Wooden Dolls: Don't forget what the Daoist said.

Jiu: You're annoying. I'm sleeping now.

Jiu: I need to run a business tomorrow. Do you even know what "business" means?

Wooden Dolls: No.

Jiu: Me neither. Maybe it means ... um ... I'll figure it out tomorrow.

6#1

What the Xiangruis Do

CH16601-02

As the sun begins to rise, so too does the sound of clanging and clattering—a cacophony of pots and pans crescendos, accompanied by the clinking of liquor jars being shuffled about.

Suddenly, the door is thrust open.

Ms. Xu: Rise and shine, girl! It's the liquor permit day. Guests are coming. It's going to be a long day. If only they would go to work as early as they come to the tavern ...

Ms. Xu: Huh? Why are you sleeping on the floor?

Ms. Xu: Did you fall down in your sleep? Get up, come on, don't get cold.

Jiu: Don't wanna wake up ...

Jiu: Sleep is good ...

Ms. Xu: What a lazy girl! No work, no food. You're not going to steal from me like you did from those vendors on the street.

Ms. Xu: I'll get you to work!

Ms. Xǔ swiftly lifts the sluggard from the ground, dusts off the dirt from her body, wipes her face, and pushes her out the door.

It seems that, for the first time in years, Jiǔ is not allowed to wake up on her own accord.

Ms. Xu: In the tavern, our business is to sell people liquor and earn money.

Ms. Xu: To work here, you'll need to be able to recognize all the liquors. Whatever the customer orders, we serve them.

Ms. Xu: Every patron, rich or poor, has their own preferences. It is only through matching those preferences that you make money in this business. A wealthy man won't always want the most expensive wine, and a poor man won't always want the cheapest.

Ms. Xu: Your first task is to memorize all the names of the different liquors.

Jiu: I don't want to do business. Too sleepy.

Jiu: And I don't want to remember anything. The street is better. I just take whatever I want.

Ms. Xu: Taking things without permission is called stealing. That's what thieves do.

Ms. Xu: Listen, here in my tavern, you need to work to get food. Otherwise, I'll only give you water.

Ms. Xu: Sweetie, every living person needs a certain job to make a living.

Ms. Xu: Yes, you'll be tired—exhausted even—but through work, you can earn the food you need.

Ms. Xu: Do you understand, Jiǔ?

Jiu: Hmm ... I guess.

Jiu: Work for food, or go hungry.

This straightforward explanation leaves no room for debate. Ms. Xǔ feels satisfied that she has corrected the girl's beggar-like behavior by a fraction or two.

Ms. Xǔ then leads Jiǔ to the front hall of the tavern.

As the sun rises higher, the streets become busier. Several early patrons have already arrived at the tavern and are now peering in from the entrance.

Ms. Xǔ quickly ushers them to their seats and ladles out their liquor, serving them according to their respective preferences. Once they settle in, Ms. Xǔ takes Jiǔ aside for more detailed instruction.

Ms. Xu: Different liquors taste different and have different costs.

Ms. Xu: There are three aspects through which you can tell liquors apart: transparency, scent, and taste.

Ms. Xu: A good liquor should be transparent, have a mellow aroma, and have a long-lasting aftertaste.

Ms. Xu: That's what the customers are after.

Accompanied by Jiǔ, Ms. Xǔ saunters past the liquor cabinet, where rows of liquor jars stand like a troop of portly warriors, awaiting the general's inspection.

The vermilion paper jackets on the jars present their whimsical nicknames, each more amusing than the last, while wafts of fragrant spirits drift from their rims.

However, Jiǔ does not recognize the characters. Instead, she memorizes the brush strokes as if they were the components of a painting.

Jiu: They smell better than flowers, and each one has a different scent!

Ms. Xu: Of course they do. Every liquor has its own unique fragrance.

Ms. Xu: Now, look at these jars. This is Fushui; the one next to it is Earth Spring; the one above is West Fair; and here is the best seller: Great Mister ...

Ms. Xu: This is the Sanle liquor. My ancestors learned the recipe from Persian merchants. It's made of multiple fruits and helps work up your appetite and digest food ...

Ms. Xu: Do you remember all that? Repeat what I just said.

Jiǔ counts on her fingers, carefully recalling each detail.

Jiu: Um ... Dirty Things, West Hair, Crazy Sir ...

Jiu: Sunny liquor ... helps workout ...

Jiǔ's words draw laughter from the patrons, who have been keenly listening to this recent round of instruction.

Old Drinker: Hahaha, what an interesting errand girl!

Old Drinker: I think her names are even better than yours!

Ms. Xu: Mr. Shěn, don't make fun of her.

Ms. Xu: What was that? She didn't recount a single word correctly!

Ms. Xu: That I would surrender to Lǐzhèng so easily! In so few words, he convinced me to commit this act of charity. And he said I was the one with the silver tongue!

Old Drinker: Hahaha, who knew that kind Ms. Xǔ could get so frustrated!

Old Drinker: You sound like a stubborn old teacher!

Ms. Xu: Not sure about the stubborn and old part, but yes, I'll have to become at least a half-teacher.

Ms. Xu: This is the little girl Lǐzhèng brought here. Her name is Jiǔ. Though she lacks social skills, she seems pretty smart.

Jiu: The Daoist said smart is good.

Old Drinker: You're being too harsh on her, Ms. Xǔ. It's not Jiǔ's fault. The names are hard to remember.

Old Drinker: You should teach her little by little, like how we start drinking liquor from a small cup, then move on to a bowl.

Old Drinker: Let her start with serving the liquor. Come, Jiǔ, give me a bowl of Earth Spring.

Ms. Xu: It's her first day; she won't know which is which. I'll get it.

Before she can move, Jiǔ dashes to the liquor cabinet. She peers left and right, fiercely sniffing the air, determined to pinpoint which jar contains Earth Spring.

Ms. Xǔ jumps on this opportunity, signaling with her eyes for Jiǔ to fetch the third jar on the first row.

Old Drinker: See, she did it! Told you she could handle it. Maybe she'll even replace you in a couple of years!

Ms. Xu: Heh heh, I couldn't ask for more! She'll do all the work, and I'll just sit back and enjoy my life. Not to mention that I won't have to deal with the mess you leave behind anymore.

Upon opening the jar of Earth Spring, a unique fragrance bursts forth. The Pèilín River winds around Pèi City, and it is from the river's upper reaches that Ms. Xǔ draws her water, for only this crisp and clear liquid can brew such a uniquely fragrant liquor.

Old Drinker is imagining the liquor from the jar filling his porcelain bowl in a steady stream. But the young girl before him plunges her hands into the jar, scoops up a handful of the crisp, exquisite liquor, and presents it to him, cupped in her hands.

Jiu: Drink, sir!

Jiu: Drink please!

Before she can finish speaking, the Earth Spring liquor has already slipped through her fingers, drenching the patron's lapel.

The tavern's patrons are at first taken aback, then they burst into hearty laughter. These guests love liquor—they cherish it dearly—but what they love even more is the atmosphere that comes with drinking it.

For these patrons, when they are enjoying liquor, all things are filled with joy.

Ms. Xu: Hahaha, sorry about this one-of-a-kind "Palm Drink." It's her first day here; please give her some patience.

Ms. Xu: Have two more bowls of West Fair. On the house!

Ms. Xu: I would give you the Earth Spring, but she put her hands into it, so I'm afraid the flavor has been altered.

Despite these apologies, Ms. Xǔ does not blame the girl. Instead, she examines her small hands over and over, fearing the strong liquor might have burned her skin. She then fetches a cloth to clean up the spilled liquor on the table.

Old Drinker is not annoyed in the slightest. Having gained two large bowls of West Fair for free, he is naturally delighted and moves to another table to continue drinking.

Jiu: Weird. He didn't get angry; he just kept drinking.

Jiu: What does liquor taste like?

Ms. Xu: It tastes ... complicated. It can bring people joy, but also great sorrow.

Ms. Xu: I'll leave it to you to find out, but only after you grow up.

Hearing this, Jiǔ immediately dips her finger into the puddle of liquor on the table, intending to taste it.

Fortunately, Ms. Xǔ intercepts her.

Ms. Xu: Hey, wait! I just said, "After you grow up!" Don't be so hasty, little lady!

Ms. Xu: And don't use your hands. I know that's how you used to drink from the troughs, but here, it's very rude.

Ms. Xu: From now on, no matter if it's water, tea, or liquor, use a bowl. It's called manners.

Ms. Xu: Hmm, tomorrow I'll buy a bowl with your name on it, so you won't confuse yours with the others. And ask questions when you don't know what to do; don't just act on impulse like you did today. Understood?

As she speaks, Ms. Xǔ tilts the liquor jar in her hand. With a gentle gurgling sound, the liquor streams like a string of glazed beads spilling onto a jade plate and fills the clay bowl of the patron in front of her.

Old Drinker: Thank you!

Jiǔ watches intently, her eyes unblinking and nostrils flared. The ethereal aroma of the liquor wafts through the air, compelling her to reach out and scoop up a handful. Then, like a beast quenching its thirst, she tilts her head back and pours it into her mouth.

Not a soul around her is quick enough to intervene. In an instant, an indescribable taste spreads across her tongue, unlike anything the child has ever tasted before.

Jiu: It, it's burning. It's burning my tongue. So hot!

Jiu: Not sweet, not bitter—something's going into my nose!

Her throat instantly begins to burn, and tears and snot threaten to run from her eyes and nose. She scrunches up her face, fanning her mouth with her hand, and smacks her tongue against the roof of her mouth.

Jiu: Bleh—this is disgusting! It burns! Why do people like this?

Ms. Xu: Oh my—! Don't do that again, Jiǔ! And you're too young to understand why.

Ms. Xu: Besides, no one can drink this kind of thing every day ...

At this moment, a patroller enters the tavern, carrying a bundle of cloth in his hand.

He stands firm in the center of the hall, surveys the room, and heads straight for Ms. Xǔ.

Patroller: Ms. Xǔ, here are some old clothes from Lǐzhèng's family. All are gently used. He said to give it to the beggar.

Ms. Xu: She's not a beggar anymore. Her name is Jiǔ. Please send my thanks to Lǐzhèng.

Ms. Xu: And thank you too, sir. You've come all the way here; why not take a rest and have a drink?

Ms. Xu: Tomorrow is the start of the liquor ban, so you'll have to wait half a month before we can serve you again.

Patroller: But I'm still on duty ...

Patroller: Oh, but could you fill my water bag for later? I'll drink with my friends after duty hours.

As Ms. Xǔ opens the jar and pours the liquor, the patrons around her begin to whisper among themselves.

Scholar Drinker: Liquor ban, liquor permit ... Look how we suffer from them!

Old Drinker: All because of that d**n regulation—"No group drinking except holidays." If only they had just banned group drinking, but they've stopped all drinking altogether!

Old Drinker: We became friends by drinking together in this tavern, but because of the ban, we have less than two weeks a month when we can even drink!

Scholar Drinker: Funny you say that, Mr. Shěn. I've seen you drinking a lot no matter on ban days or permit days.

Old Drinker: Shh! Watch your mouth ...

The two patrons steal a glance at the patroller nearby, their voices fading to a whisper ...

The daylight hours fly by swiftly. Come nightfall, Jiǔ lies on her bed, soreness in her body and weariness in her legs. She has run back and forth through the front hall all day.

Wooden Doll: In the darkness, the wooden dolls emerge once more, hopping onto the bed one after another and dancing beside her.

Wooden Dolls: Lying down! Lying down!

Wooden Dolls: Working is exhausting; working is hard!

Wooden Dolls: How was the "business"?

Jiu: "Business" is tiring. But there are interesting things! Dirty Things, West Hair, Crazy Sir ...

Jiu: These are very spicy liquors, you know.

Wooden Dolls: Don't know at all. Where is Xiángruì?

Wooden Dolls: Xiángruì, don't forget!

Jiu: Stop rushing me. I'll look for it! The people here know so many things, especially Ms. Xǔ.

Jiu: But, Xiángruì ... what exactly is a Xiángruì?

6#1

Idle Time

CH16601-03

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, no customers today?

Ms. Xu: Afraid not. We're on liquor ban after all.

Jiu Niangzi: Who decided what to do on different days, anyway? Isn't today just a normal day like any other?

Much time passes ... Jiǔ has grown considerably taller, no longer bearing the feral appearance she once had. The patrons have bestowed upon her the nickname "Jiǔ Niángzǐ," regarding her as a young maiden charged with selling and serving liquor, and indeed, as Ms. Xǔ's successor.

It didn't take long for her to shed her childhood demeanor. These days, she is immersed in the atmosphere of the tavern. She converses back and forth with the patrons with ease.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ half-heartedly wipes the dust off the liquor jars, having counted the bowls behind the counter numerous times.

She wanders the hall, idle and bored, and begins to read the "Regulations on Liquor Sale and Consumption" placard posted on one of the pillars.

Jiu Niangzi: I can't read it, save for a few characters. The customers talk about it all the time.

Jiu Niangzi: So often that I can even recite it now: "This regulation aims to prioritize the use of grain for food over liquor ..."

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ reads it during the liquor ban too, as if it could make the permit days come sooner.

The regulations are filled with verbose and tedious phrases, but it is only at the end that it clearly states:

"Citizens are permitted to drink during holidays and on the first and 15th days of the month. Drinking is prohibited on all other days, including group drinking, private drinking, and the sale of liquor in taverns."

Jiu Niangzi: If not liquor, what else would be sold in a tavern? Whoever made this decision clearly doesn't understand what people want.

Jiu Niangzi: Or do they? There are lots of rules here that don't let people do what they want. Is it on purpose?

Jiu Niangzi: Lǐzhèng manages the merchant hub ... Is he a guardian? Is he a Xiángruì?

A knock echoes at the door. In accordance with the regulations, the tavern can only open the door halfway on liquor ban days.

A patron slips into the front hall, flipping a few copper coins in hand and greeting like an old friend.

Citizen IV: Ms. Xǔ, I'll have three rice buns. The freshly made ones.

Citizen IV: Truly, no one makes better rice buns than you!

Citizen IV: Can't you save me some next time? Every time I'm a little bit late, they're sold out.

On the table lies a large basket, brimming with small, golden, crispy buns with sesame seeds sprinkled on top. Here, they are known simply as rice buns.

Ms. Xǔ moves as fast as serving liquor, picks out three rice buns, and hands them over to the patron.

Ms. Xu: Glad you like them. As you know, we can't do liquor business during the ban.

Ms. Xu: Luckily, the rice we use to make liquor can be made into buns. We wouldn't be able to make a living if we didn't make these, and of course, if we didn't have your and the neighborhood's support.

Citizen IV: Hey, isn't this Jiǔ Niángzǐ? I thought you just slept in the back during the liquor ban.

Jiu Niangzi: Sleep? No work, no food. It's as simple as that.

Jiu Niangzi: So I need to work too. Sweep the floor, wipe the jars—all the cleaning, really.

Citizen IV: Look at you, giving me a full speech.

Citizen IV: I remember when you first got here. You could barely say a full sentence!

Citizen IV: What a blessing it is that Ms. Xǔ took you in. She's fed and taught you all this time. Make sure you thank her properly when you've grown up, eh?

Jiu Niangzi: Blessing ... Hmm, blessing ...

Ms. Xǔ takes out a small cup and fills it with the tea from the teapot on the counter, inviting the visitor to drink it.

Citizen IV: Thank you. I always get thirsty on my trip over here ... My, what nice tea this is!

Citizen IV: A sip of clear tea like this is sure to melt the worries away. You really know how to run a business, Ms. Xǔ.

Ms. Xu: You flatter me. I'm just putting myself in the customer's shoes.

Ms. Xu: It's the only way to run a long-lasting business. With the liquor ban ongoing, I'm counting on rice buns and tea to make a living.

Throughout the morning, a steady stream of customers come to buy her buns, until only seven or eight remain in the basket. Those who come too late truly will miss out.

After purchasing their buns, the patrons always make a point to drink a cup of tea in the tavern, draining it in one gulp. Only then do they leave contented.

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ, the buns are selling quickly. Every time I go to the street, people ask me if there are any left.

Jiu Niangzi: Why don't we just sell buns instead of liquor? Then we wouldn't need to run around and serve the patrons.

Jiu Niangzi: We'd just sit here and pass the buns to the customers.

Ms. Xu: What are you talking about? We're running a tavern, not a bakery.

Ms. Xu: People buy our buns because they're made in a tavern. If we didn't make liquor, we wouldn't have the ingredients to make them.

Jiu Niangzi: But aren't they made of rice?

The rice buns in the basket continue to emit their fragrance, a scent both familiar and foreign to Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She has never seen how these buns are made.

She retires early each night, only to awaken to the enticing aroma the next morning. By then, Ms. Xǔ has already prepared a basket full of rice buns and is setting them up on the table.

Ms. Xu: Yes, but not entirely. They're made with the rice from the tavern.

Ms. Xu: We use grain to make liquor, including rice, wheat, millet, and many others.

Ms. Xu: You see, I always go to the grain store myself to get the best ingredients.

Ms. Xu: After liquor is made, the lees left are called Jiǔniàng. Similar to your name. Rice buns are made of Jiǔniàng and buckwheat flour.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, I didn't know that. No wonder it smells better than other buns.

Ms. Xu: But it comes at a cost. Making buns is more tiring than making liquor!

As she speaks, Ms. Xǔ playfully taps the tip of Jiǔ Niángzǐ's nose.

Ms. Xu: The freshly made rice buns taste the best. They lose their fragrance after a day.

Ms. Xu: To make the buns, we need to take the Jiǔniàng out of the liquor jar before three in the morning and mix the flour before five, knead and shape nearly a hundred of them, then heat the earthen oven and put them inside ...

Ms. Xu: I wouldn't have to work so hard if there were no liquor bans, let alone the neighborhood is counting on me to make the buns.

Jiu Niangzi: Neighborhood is counting on you ...

Jiu Niangzi: People need Ms. Xǔ ...

Though Ms. Xǔ speaks only of making buns and other mundane tasks, she gives her listener pause for thought.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's heart stirs, and she suddenly recalls the words of the Daoist.

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ, do you know what a Xiángruì is?

Jiu Niangzi: I heard that it's something good.

Ms. Xu: Where did you hear about that? Oh, from the drinkers, of course.

Ms. Xu: They're just drunk and talking nonsense. Don't take it seriously.

Ms. Xu: But I have heard about Xiángruì. They say they're divine beasts, guardians with special power.

Jiu Niangzi: Have you seen it before? Can I see it?

Upon hearing that Ms. Xǔ holds some insight on Xiángruì, Jiǔ Niángzǐ becomes quite agitated, eagerly moving closer to her.

Ms. Xǔ has no choice but to guide Jiǔ Niángzǐ to first take a seat before she begins speaking to her properly.

Ms. Xu: Easy, girl. There's not much I can tell you.

Ms. Xu: The frequenters said that, before the bridge was broken, this city had a Xiángruì as a guardian.

Ms. Xu: It looked like a horse, and it ran faster than the wind. But its story is long lost to time; no one knows if it's real.

Jiu Niangzi: Do you know what a Xiángruì does? Or how to become one?

Ms. Xu: Um, just like in every story, they help people when they need it and disappear soon after they're safe.

Ms. Xu: As for how to become one ... They're monsters and Yāos. I've never heard of a person becoming a Xiángruì.

Seeing Jiǔ Niángzǐ sitting there with her ears perked up, she dares not hold back a single word.

Ms. Xu: You're just like that boy from the silk store. He, too, could listen to the stories of Yāos and monsters all day long.

Ms. Xu: He asks people about the stories in The Classic of Mountains and Seas every single day. Little by little, he learned how to read without ever going to school.

Ms. Xu: If you want to know more about Xiángruì, maybe Mr. Liǔ from the clinic can help. He's knowledgeable. He might be able to teach you how to read.

Ms. Xu: And then you can help me with the bookkeeping or writing toasts.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ feels a surge of joy within her. If she could read, then she could read books, and, as she has heard many say, books contain absolutely everything—surely, that includes everything about the Xiángruì, too.

Without hesitation, she agrees and promptly sets out to find Mr. Liǔ.

Ms. Xu: Oh, before you go, take this.

Ms. Xǔ pulls out a sheet of jute paper, carefully wraps twelve buns within it, and ties it up.

She then takes out some coins and asks Jiǔ Niángzǐ to give them to Mr. Liǔ together with the buns.

Jiu Niangzi: Are the coins for medicine? Are you sick?

Ms. Xu: No, silly, it's not for me. It's for the favor you're about to ask.

Ms. Xu: Sweetie, when you're asking someone for a favor, you don't come empty-handed. That's one manner in socializing. You still have a lot to learn.

Jiu Niangzi: So, buns and money equal good etiquette?

Jiu Niangzi: How strange. It is heavy to carry.

As the half-moon wanes and the new moon rises, the streets bustle with life. Now, on each liquor ban afternoon, Jiǔ Niángzǐ visits the clinic at the end of the street to meet Mr. Liǔ and learn the art of letters and words.

To avoid disturbing the clinic's work, Jiǔ Niángzǐ often brings a small stool to sit on by the doorway.

Jiu Niangzi: "As warmth fades, the cold follows, the autumn harvest begins ..."

Jiu Niangzi: "Autumn harvest begins" ... and, um, ...

Mr. Liu: "And we hoard food for winter." Jiǔ Niángzǐ, are you still having trouble reciting Thousand Character Classic?

Mr. Liu: I'm confused. You learn everything quickly, except for reading. Every time I teach you how to read something, you forget it right away.

Mr. Liu: I suppose not everyone is gifted enough to read.

Jiu Niangzi: Reading is so much harder than serving liquor. I always get a headache when I start reading something ...

Jiu Niangzi: And these characters look like earthworms ...

Mr. Liu: "Sky black, earth golden. Vast universe, limitless cosmos." Knowledge and culture were easily lost before Cāngjié invented characters. Through reading these "earthworms," wisdom, discipline, and manners have been passed down for generations.

Mr. Liu: One is not civilized until one is able to read—able to read the books of the sages at that.

Jiu Niangzi: That Cāngjié sounds like a bad guy.

Jiu Niangzi: He could've made the characters easier to read if he really wanted people to learn.

Mr. Liu: ...

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Liǔ, do you know what a Xiángruì is? Ms. Xǔ said that you're knowledgeable and would be able to answer my questions.

Mr. Liu: The so called Xiángruì ...

Mr. Liǔ pauses momentarily. Fortunately, his proclivity for reading allows him to address the question with ease, thus preserving his dignity in front of the young lady.

Mr. Liu: ... also known as "the sign of auspiciousness." When it appears, it's a good omen from heaven, and things will go well.

Mr. Liu: But its form is unpredictable. It could be a colorful cloud, two-spike wheat, or a dry spring that somehow flourishes. Under some circumstances, it could even be an exotic beast.

The phrase "exotic beast" strikes Jiǔ Niángzǐ like a hammer, prompting her to inquire further.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh! Do you know how an animal becomes a Xiángruì?

Mr. Liu: Uh, um ... How could I know? The books I read are the philosophical studies of sages and scholars, not monster stories for children.

Jiu Niangzi: Then you don't know anything either. I thought you knew everything.

These words leave Mr. Liǔ speechless. All he can do is scratch his head.

Suddenly, he remembers that there are other ways to chronicle the world's wonders besides words. He strides into the clinic and reemerges with several dusty, time-worn tomes in hand.

As he unfurls their pages, they reveal coarsely printed illustrations of mountain spirits and wild monsters, each annotated in a diminutive square script.

Mr. Liu: Here, these are picture books about the monster stories you like. There's only a little text.

Mr. Liu: You can research the Xiángruì legends while learning some characters. Two birds, one stone, and all that.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ takes the book and cradles it gently in her hands. She turns the pages in awe.

Seizing this quiet moment, Mr. Liǔ takes out two rice buns and places a large bowl on the counter.

Jiu Niangzi: I want a rice bun, too.

Mr. Liu: So you can drink. I thought Ms. Xǔ said you didn't like the taste of liquor.

Mr. Liu: Even the most experienced drinker can't eat a rice bun without water.

Jiu Niangzi: What are you talking about? I don't drink. I just want to know what the rice buns taste like. Ms. Xǔ's never let me have one before.

Mr. Liu: Oh dear, so Ms. Xǔ didn't tell you. I fear I've said too much ...

Mr. Liu: But you do live in the tavern and help her do all the work. It's only a matter of time before you find out ... Alright, I'll show you.

Mr. Liǔ carefully crumbles a rice bun into the bowl. He then pours hot tea over it, and a familiar aroma wafts into Jiǔ Niángzǐ's nostrils.

That mellow fermented fragrance, mixed with the dry scent of sesame and the smoky aroma of the roasted hearth, fills the air.

Jiu Niangzi: Whoa, the water turns the bun into liquor!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ leans over the counter, her delicate face reflected in the bowl. The rice bun has dissolved, leaving only a few grains at the bottom of the bowl.

Mr. Liu: Because of the liquor ban, we can't directly buy liquor, so Ms. Xǔ came up with this rice bun idea.

Mr. Liu: The Jiǔniàng used in the buns is specially made, keeping most of the alcohol in it, so that the bun has a strong smell of alcohol.

Mr. Liu: Eating it is like drinking distilled alcohol; only a drunkard could handle that.

Mr. Liu: But watering it down makes it easy to drink. A bowl of this liquor can take all your worries away.

Jiu Niangzi: So that's why people come and buy buns during the liquor ban.

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ is so clever. What a creative way to give people drinks!

Mr. Liu: Drinking a bowl or two and getting lost in our own thoughts. This is one of a few entertainments for us common people.

Mr. Liu: The liquor ban has led to some inventive ways for people to get their liquor.

Mr. Liu: Luckily, the government is not very strict about it, and thanks to Ms. Xǔ, drinkers like us can have a sip when we want.

Jiu Niangzi: I never knew that ... Ms. Xǔ is really helping people.

Jiu Niangzi: I should do that too. As soon as I get back to the tavern, I'll tell her that I'll help her deliver the buns.

This spirited young girl, showing such audacity in her utter indifference to the laws against liquor, earns nothing but admiration from Mr. Liǔ.

Mr. Liu: But remember, you didn't hear this from me.

Jiu Niangzi: You didn't tell me anything. I figured it out myself.

6#1

A Place to Belong

CH16601-04

Time slips away, and despite the arrival of another liquor ban day, the tavern seems busier than usual.

It is only morning, and the tavern is already bustling with life. The door stands ajar, as per tradition, allowing the scent of sesame to drift outward as fresh rice buns tumble into baskets, their steam coiling into the air.

Unlike previous days, another petite figure waits nearby, wearing light walking shoes and carrying a soft cloth bundle.

Ms. Xu: 41, 42, 43 ...

Ms. Xu: 50 rice buns in total, fresh out of the oven. Smells good; worth the hard work. I was up before the sun.

Ms. Xu: Do you think you can make it? You'll have to walk through basically half the city to deliver all the buns.

Jiu Niangzi: Don't worry, it's not my first time. I'll run as fast as I can!

Ms. Xu: Still remember our customers and their orders?

Jiu Niangzi: Sure I do. Two buns for the butcher on West Street, four for the tea room on South Alley, the family across the bridge wants three, and, um ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ retrieves a piece of paper from her sleeve, upon which a map has been haphazardly drawn, marking the locations of the shops she must deliver to today.

Jiu Niangzi: See, I wrote it down. Since I've learned how to read and write, I can remember them easily!

Upon closer inspection, the list would give most people a good laugh. Aside from a few familiar characters, the rest is made up of drawings resembling an encrypted espionage missive.

It is highly unlikely that anyone but her would be able to decipher it.

Ms. Xu: Be careful. Stay alert to the patrollers. If you're thirsty, just ask for a cup of tea when you get to the tea room. The owner will give you one.

Jiu Niangzi: Yeah, alright.

Before she finishes her sentence, Jiǔ Niángzǐ is dashing out the door, taking huge swift strides as she runs down the street and disappears into the distance. Compared to that little beggar of years past, she looks like a completely different person.

Without Jiǔ Niángzǐ's help, it would not be possible to deliver rice buns to people in other districts of the city. Ms. Xǔ shines with gratitude.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, should I go east or west first? Or I could start with the closer ones, and then the farther ones ...

Jiu Niangzi: So many orders to deliver. So many people to meet.

Amidst her musings, a wooden doll peeks its head out from the sleeve of her garment.

Wooden Dolls: And things about Xiángruì to ask. Don't forget!

Jiu Niangzi: Oh right, Xiángruì. I need to ask around.

Jiu Niangzi: Hey, I didn't call you. Why did you come out? Hide; quickly!

After tucking the wooden doll back into her sleeve, Jiǔ Niángzǐ spends half the day running through the city and delivers over half of the rice buns.

Now, guided by her own map, she arrives at the edge of an alley and knocks on a weathered wooden door.

Poet: Coming, I'm coming! Finally, the font of my inspiration has arrived.

Poet: I've been waiting all day, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Lǐ, the buns you ordered are here.

Poet: Great, great. I'll get water to mix them together.

Mr. Lǐ's hands are stained with ink, and looking in from the doorway, the room appears to be strewn with sheets of white rice paper, the fresh ink still glistening on their surfaces.

In the tavern, where the town's drinkers gather, none are unaware of the poetic talents of Mr. Lǐ. A lover of verse and ink, he often likens himself to the great poets, Du Fu and Li Bai.

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Lǐ, are you still writing poems?

Poet: The tavern was too noisy. By the time I got home, my inspirations had all been driven away. Luckily, today is liquor ban day, so I woke up with a clearer mind.

Poet: I woke up before seven this morning and started creating right away. But hot liquor will help my ideas flow. Thanks for the buns!

Mr. Lǐ dissolves a rice bun in tea, and with a single gulp, he drinks it down. Within moments, a flush of color spreads across his face.

Poet: Excellent! What a drink. What an excellent mood I'm in now!

Witnessing this scene, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's curiosity is piqued. Since she started working at the tavern, she has seen all manner of drinkers, yet she remains unaware of the reasons behind their indulgence.

Jiu Niangzi: People say drinking makes you smarter. Is that so?

Poet: I can't speak for others, but it doesn't make me smarter, but bolder. Often, without drinking, I feel fettered, and I can't write a single word.

Poet: But a bowl of liquor emboldens me, like I'm a general riding a horse, running on the field of creativity.

Poet: And somehow, the poems I write when I'm in this mood are better than the others.

Jiu Niangzi: Sounds like liquor can give people energy.

Jiu Niangzi: The guests are always energetic and loud after drinking.

Poet: By the way, I heard you've been studying with Mr. Liǔ. Why didn't you come to me?

Poet: I'm much more accomplished than him—intelligent and erudite. Let me read something to you: Goose, goose, goose ...

Jiǔ Niángzǐ hastily excuses herself, saying that she still has many buns to deliver, and scurries away.

Thus, Jiǔ Niángzǐ traverses several streets more until she arrives at another household and knocks on the door.

Her knock resounds. The door is opened by an elderly man with graying hair—a familiar face often seen at the tavern.

Old Drinker: Finally! The taste of the rice bun liquor lingers in my mouth for days. Using half a bun a day is equal to four days' drinking!

Old Drinker: Thank you, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, for delivering them for me. And send my thanks to Ms. Xǔ as well.

As Jiǔ Niángzǐ hands over the rice buns, she suddenly recalls the wooden doll's admonition.

Jiu Niangzi: Mr. Shěn, could you tell me more about the Xiángruì you mentioned in the tavern that day?

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ told me you've met a lot of people and know a lot of things. Maybe that includes a story about Xiángruì, too.

Old Drinker: Why are you suddenly asking me this? But she's right that I know many things.

Old Drinker: It is an age-old story. Every Xiángruì looks different, resides in different locations, and has their own duty.

Jiu Niangzi: From what I know, a Xiángruì blesses its people. But how does the blessing work?

Old Drinker leans against the door frame. For some time, he strokes his whiskers as he contemplates how to give Jiǔ Niángzǐ a satisfactory answer.

Old Drinker: The blessing, I'd say, satisfies the wishes of the people.

Old Drinker: Like Ms. Xǔ and her tavern. She provides a place for drinkers like me to enjoy liquor and makes these rice buns when drinking is banned.

Old Drinker: She is such a blessing, with much more bark than bite. And the liquor she makes is so smooth, it whisks away my sorrows.

Old Drinker then falls into reminiscence as he begins muttering to himself.

Old Drinker: Liquor ... I suppose liquor is a good thing. It comforts people.

Old Drinker: I was once too young to enjoy it, and now I'm too old to enjoy life.

Old Drinker: Only a bowl of liquor can take me back to enjoying that youth that I can only visit in my dreams.

As the sun is setting and Jiǔ Niángzǐ still has several rice buns yet to deliver, she bids farewell to Old Drinker and hurries off. As she glances back, she sees him sitting by the door, cradling his rice buns and liquor, and softly humming a tune.

On her journey, Jiǔ Niángzǐ contemplates the "blessing" Old Drinker mentioned. Guided by her map, she unknowingly steps onto the threshold of the last house on her list.

Zhici

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ runs the tavern to satisfy people's wishes to drink ... Is that a "blessing"?

Jiu Niangzi: To become a Xiángruì, I need to ...

Lost in thought, Jiǔ Niángzǐ finds her path obstructed by a formidable figure. The man, out of habit, presses down on the short sword at his waist, adjusts its position, and clears his throat to remind her of his presence.

Facao: Seeing that Jiǔ Niángzǐ is still lost in her reverie, the man clears his throat once more.

Facao: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you're late.

Facao: Two hours late. Lucky for you, Lǐzhèng is still working on the ledger of the New Year's purchase.

Jiu Niangzi: Fǎ-Fǎcáo, why are you here? What's late?

Jiu Niangzi: I'm just, um, wandering on the street. I don't know what you're talking about.

Recalling Ms. Xǔ's words, she quickly takes a step back to distance herself from him.

Facao: You have around seven or eight buns with you, do you not? You can give them to me now.

Jiu Niangzi: ...

After a moment's hesitation, Jiǔ Niángzǐ hands over the rest of the buns, her heart pounding in her chest, anticipating the judgment of the law.

Unsure of what the punishment might be for breaking the liquor ban, Jiǔ Niángzǐ waits silently.

But he does not blame her. Instead, he fishes out seven or eight copper coins from his person and counts them out before presenting them to her.

Jiu Niangzi: This is ...?

Facao: It's for the buns. We officers aren't freeloaders.

Facao: Hurry. Take this.

Jiu Niangzi: Um, they're rice buns ... made from the materials from making liquor, if you just eat them like that—

Facao: I know. Yesterday I sent someone to the tavern and asked that they be sent to the Zhící.

Facao: I expected you to arrive earlier.

Facao: A member of the patrol team just got promoted. We've been waiting for this to celebrate—

As he speaks, a figure emerges from the Zhící, exuding an air of authority and kindness. It is Lǐzhèng. Jiǔ Niángzǐ hasn't seen him for quite some time.

Lizheng: My work is done here. Time to head back, Fǎcáo.

Lizheng: Hmm? Isn't this Jiǔ Niángzǐ? You've grown up now.

Lizheng: I heard you're doing a good job in the tavern. The patrollers always talk about you.

Jiu Niangzi: Thank you, Lǐzhèng.

Lizheng: But what are you two talking about? Is there something I should know?

Facao: ...

Jiu Niangzi: N-nothing! I'm just asking Fǎcáo about, um, about ...

Jiu Niangzi: About Xiángruì! I've been studying with Mr. Liǔ these days and saw the word "Xiángruì." It's said to be some divine beast that protects people, but nothing more.

Jiu Niangzi: So I was asking him about the Xiángruì in Pèi City.

Lizheng: Perhaps it's been recorded in the collections at the county archive.

Jiu Niangzi: Can I check them?

Lizheng: Citizens are prohibited from entering the archive. Along with the collections, the classified county annuals are preserved there.

Lizheng: Put your curiosity away, Jiǔ Niángzǐ; it's time for you to go back home now.

With Lǐzhèng and Fǎcáo fading into the distance, Jiǔ Niángzǐ gives her bundle a shake, catches some sesame seeds in her hand, and starts chewing on them.

Throughout the day, Jiǔ Niángzǐ encountered many individuals, but Fǎcáo's actions intrigued her more than anything else. It seems this prohibition is indeed as lax as Ms. Xǔ claimed. So why, she wonders, has it not yet been abolished?

6#1

Time Slipping Away

CH16601-05

Months pass. The biting north wind heralds the coming of the Dùshuò Festival, together with liquor permit days, so the tavern has been buzzing with guests for several days.

The front hall is warmed by a charcoal fire, creating a cozy and festive atmosphere.

In recent days, the town's celebrated Storyteller has taken the stage once again, spending several days narrating tales in the tavern.

Storyteller: It is said ...

The Storyteller's voice booms throughout the room. His tales are so captivating that they seize the ears of all present. Within a few sentences, even the most avid drinkers forget to raise their cups to their lips.

Storyteller: It is said there is a place haunted by miasma in the south of the land. The miasma there shifts its form into many Yāos, and they attack people.

Storyteller: Meanwhile, in the Central Plains, a monster originating from dryness dominates. Wherever it goes, drought follows, and people suffer famine.

Storyteller: The rivers and lakes are overrun with huge snakes called Gōushé. They are more than 20 meters long with hooks on their tails, hooking people and cows into the water to eat them.

Storyteller: To prevent these monsters from hurting people, Yāo hunters travel the world searching haunted places in order to expel them with their special power.

Storyteller: They are the sword against evil, protecting people with their lives.

Jiu Niangzi: Are they ... Xiángruì?

Storyteller: Not at all. A Yāo hunter is not a Xiángruì.

Poet: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, one more bowl of Great Mister!

Poet: Jiǔ Niángzǐ!

She is completely engrossed in the Storyteller's narrative, remaining oblivious to her surroundings until Ms. Xǔ comes over and tugs her sleeve.

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, quickly, a guest is calling you.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, ok, one more bowl coming!

Ms. Xu: Forgive her; it's her first time listening to a professional Storyteller. She's been fascinated for the last few days.

Poet: Don't worry, I understand. He tells stories much better than we do. It's no wonder she's so absorbed.

Poet: It's too bad he only comes to the city during the Dùshuò Festival.

Ms. Xu: Speaking of which, it'll be a lot of work to decorate the tavern. Look at all these lanterns, candles, and ribbons!

Ms. Xu: Luckily, I have Jiǔ Niángzǐ to help me this year. What a busy year she's had. She ran errands, learned how to read, and delivered rice buns all around the city.

Ms. Xu: Though she still has a lot more to learn, she continues to impress me with her work ethic.

At this moment, a guest enters the tavern. Seeing the joyous festival celebrations, he smiles and finds a seat.

Lizheng: One bowl of Great Mister, please.

Ms. Xu: What a surprise it is to see you here, Lǐzhèng! Here, drinks are on me.

Ms. Xu: This is newly made. Have a try.

Lizheng: I don't usually drink, but we are in the countdown to the Dùshuò Festival, so I suppose I'll have a bowl or two. Besides, I have something I want to confirm with you.

Lizheng: Remember when we brought Jiǔ Niángzǐ here, you refused to take her in until we appointed you as supplier of the ceremonial liquor?

Lizheng: Well, the festival is near now, and I finally have some time to come by. I want to ask: How are the preparations going?

Ms. Xu: Already done. They're in the yard. Eight jars of liquor, all made with the best ingredients.

Ms. Xu: It was the request that I took most seriously all year! If anything goes wrong with them, people will lose their faith in me.

Lǐzhèng nods in satisfaction, knowing that Ms. Xǔ has taken her role to heart.

Lizheng: Relax. I'm just asking. The Zhílǐ is the one checking all the ceremonial supplies.

Lizheng: Dùshuò is the biggest festival of the year. The merchant's hub will be packed with people during this time. I need to make sure everything goes smoothly.

Ms. Xu: Oh, for a second, I thought this was a full inspection. You almost had me panicking.

Ms. Xu: I was thinking, "Zhílǐ has already checked the liquor; why is he checking again? Have I done something wrong?"

Hearing their lively conversation, Old Drinker joins them.

Old Drinker: Lǐzhèng, I heard the festoon race is rerunning this year. Do you know when, exactly?

Old Drinker: You see, most of us don't know much about divination, ancient articles, or singing ... But racing is nice and simple. Whoever runs fastest wins.

Lizheng: It'll be around the end of the year, but it's not decided yet. Some items, such as the festoons and flagpoles, are all prepared.

Lizheng: I wonder who'll win this year.

Jiu Niangzi: Festoons, flagpoles, winner ...

Jiu Niangzi: What's the festoon race?

Ms. Xu: It's just a few layabouts running around, really ... It's only ...

Old Drinker chuckles and waves his hand, taking over the conversation.

Old Drinker: Let me explain. The festoon race is a racing event. Five flagpoles are set up at five locations in the city, each with multiple festoons of the same color.

Old Drinker: There's no fixed route for the race. After it starts, the runners can collect five festoons in any order, as long as they finish with the red one.

Old Drinker: The first to get the red wins, and the Zhící will grant him a wish.

Jiu Niangzi: A wish ... Any wish?

Seeing Jiǔ Niángzǐ's enthusiasm, Lǐzhèng strokes his beard, a smile growing on his face.

Lizheng: Not if you're wishing for a star in the sky. Most people ask for some grains, clothes, or other daily necessities. Others ask for jade pendants, tea bricks, and the like.

Lizheng: Nothing worth more than a few loads of rice.

Jiu Niangzi: Can I wish to go to the county archive and read the books there?

Lizheng: Well ... Probably, yes. If you win the race, that is.

After a brief chat, Lǐzhèng takes his leave, and Ms. Xǔ hurries over to speak with Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, are you serious about joining the festoon race?

Ms. Xu: Every past winner has been a patroller! They're strong and, of course, know the city like the back of their hands.

Jiu Niangzi: I know the city well, too! I deliver buns all over the city all the time!

Jiu Niangzi: And I'm a fast runner! Much faster than before!

Ms. Xu: Well, you surely are ... But I'm worried you might get hurt during the race.

Ms. Xu: If something goes wrong, who'll take over the—

Ms. Xu: See me in the yard tonight. I have something to tell you.

As night falls, the courtyard is stripped of its daytime clamor, leaving only the liquor jars standing against the wall. There is no sound but the gurgling of water—a babbling particularly pronounced in the stillness of the night.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ, mimicking Ms. Xǔ, dips the liquor ladle into the vat, scooping out the lees to place in a wooden basin.

By the time she reaches the kitchen, an oil lamp has already been lit on the table, with wheat flour piled beside it.

Ms. Xu: The key is the ratio of ingredients.

Ms. Xu: Four cups of Jiǔniàng and one cup of wheat flour. No water.

Ms. Xu: Before you mix them together, you need to squeeze the liquor out of it, so the bun will be chewy.

Ms. Xu: Always use newly ground wheat flour. Inspect the flour for any large particles; it should be as fine as rouge powder.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ follows each step as Ms. Xǔ instructs her. She mixes the lees with the wheat flour and, using a special technique, patiently kneads them together.

Initially, the lees do not integrate with the wheat flour, but as she works it with her palms, they start to merge together, giving rise to a faint fragrance—milder than the lees but richer than the flour.

Jiu Niangzi: It's fun to make. The dough is soft and white. What's next?

Jiu Niangzi: Flatten it and put it in the earthen oven?

Ms. Xu: Not quite. There's one last step. Stay calm, alright? There's no need to be afraid.

Ms. Xǔ brings out a square wooden board and scatters a handful of wheat grain upon it. She then tilts a bowl of water, flicking her fingers to sprinkle water over the grain.

She mutters under her breath, and, in a matter of moments, the wheat grains begin to sprout open, growing upward as if devouring the air itself.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ watches the scene intently as the wheat sprouts on the table grow to the length of her palm before coming to a halt.

Jiu Niangzi: You—you know magic?

Ms. Xu: It's my arcane skill, nothing special. I can hasten the growth of malt. Actually, there are many others in the city who can do much more.

Ms. Xǔ slices the freshly sprouted malt, chops it finely, and blends it into the well-kneaded dough.

Ms. Xu: This is the secret to our rice buns. The malt. It takes days for it to grow naturally, but my skill saves a lot of time.

Ms. Xu: Have you had malt before?

Jiu Niangzi: No, but I know it can be made into candy.

Ms. Xu: It can make liquor, too. My father was the one who brought the recipe for ale to the city.

Ms. Xu: He was a merchant traveling the world. After he met my mother, he decided to stay here and opened this tavern.

Ms. Xu: When I was a little girl, my mother always said that, thanks to my arcane skill, we could make liquor faster than any other tavern.

Ms. Xu: And my father told me stories of his travels. Today, what the Storyteller said about ...

Ms. Xǔ's voice grows fainter, her mind drifting off, as though she were recalling some past event.

Ms. Xu: My yearning to travel the world gets stronger day by day, yet here I am, still at this tavern ...

Ms. Xu: There's always something that stops me from getting out of the city, or even out the front gate, for that matter.

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ ...

Jiu Niangzi: Are you also trapped here?

Ms. Xǔ's gaze falls upon the flickering candlelight. The shadows of the room seem to have taken the shape of things from long ago. She simply shakes her head.

Ms. Xǔ looks at Jiǔ Niángzǐ and sees a reflection of her younger self. Suddenly, she feels a weariness enveloping her.

Ms. Xu: Forget it. Go to sleep, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Go to sleep.

After returning to her room, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's thoughts linger on Ms. Xǔ. It seems the people of Pèi City all have their individual worries, be it Lǐzhèng, Ms. Xǔ, or the patrons.

A familiar rustling emanates from the corners of the room, starting as a soft whisper and gradually swelling into song as the wooden dolls once again appear atop her bed.

Wooden Dolls: Make buns, make buns!

Wooden Dolls: Rice buns! Grow malt!

A wooden doll climbs up Jiǔ Niángzǐ's sleeve.

Wooden Dolls: You have, personal feelings.

Wooden Dolls: You treat her as family. You will never be a Xiángruì.

Jiu Niangzi: Hey, stop! Shut up!

Jiu Niangzi: I don't have any personal feelings, okay?! So just stop talking!

Wooden Dolls: Can't be a Xiángruì! Can't go out of the city! Forever and ever.

Jiu Niangzi: I won't stay here forever ... I won't!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ turns her back, doing her best to ignore the encroaching chaos, yet her heart remains plunged into turmoil.

6#1

Festoons

CH16601-06

Ms. Xu: Let me see ... Everything's sorted. Not many customers today, so I can handle things on my own.

Ms. Xu: Why don't you wear something lighter?

Jiu Niangzi: It's ok. I'm used to this. It's my delivery outfit.

Jiu Niangzi: I'm a fast runner. My clothes won't slow me down.

Ms. Xu: Last night, I had your shoes resoled. Oh, and I put new insoles inside.

Ms. Xu: Hopefully, they'll be more comfortable than before.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ looks down and presses into the floor with the tip of her foot. She then paces back and forth a few times.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, that's why they feel so much softer today. They're much easier to walk on than before. Thank you, Ms. Xǔ.

Jiu Niangzi: They won't chafe when I'm running now.

As the conversation unfolds, someone approaches from outside the tavern.

Poet: Hey, Ms. Xǔ, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Are you going out?

Poet: Today isn't a liquor ban day. I'd like a bowl of Earth Spring to get some inspiration for my poem.

Ms. Xu: Sorry, not many people have come today due to the festoon race.

Ms. Xu: And Jiǔ Niángzǐ has signed up for the race. So I just decided to close up and go cheer her on.

Poet: Well, it is indeed the most lively day of the year. Everyone's gathered on the street.

Poet: But if you close your door, where can we drinkers go to kill time?

Ms. Xu: Sorry, but it's not every day that I'll get to see Jiǔ Niángzǐ participate in a race.

Poet: Alright. Then, I suppose, I'll take a look too.

She locks the door, and they head out onto the street together.

On most days, only a handful of people can be found by the city gates, but today, the area is alive with townspeople.

This is the starting line of the festoon race. All manner of people are waiting at the line—from fruit vendors to the old nightwatchman. They are stretching and rubbing their hands together in anticipation, eager for the event to begin.

Lizheng: Hmm. There seem to be many more contestants than in previous years.

Lizheng: Presumably, a number of them are newcomers to the city.

Facao: Recent years have been kind, and life has been good. The citizens have had a plentiful harvest and very little disease.

Facao: Of course more of them are willing to join the race.

Lizheng: Food comes first for the people. Only a full stomach and warmth can make one wealthy. Even this tradition started as a ceremony to pray for a good harvest for the next year.

Lizheng: Since you're standing by my side, I assume you won't be joining the race this year?

Facao: I haven't done so for years. But I recommended a few members of the patrol team join.

Facao: Oh, and I heard Jiǔ Niángzǐ from the tavern signed up.

Lizheng: Is that so? I thought she was joking. She truly is a brave girl.

Ms. Xu: Excuse me! Make way!

Ms. Xu: Sorry, excuse me! We have a contestant here!

Passing by these robust men only serves to highlight her delicate stature.

With her agile frame, Jiǔ Niángzǐ weaves through the crowd.

Jiu Niangzi: So many people ...

Jiu Niangzi: Please, excuse me! Let me through!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ becomes as nimble as a loach, threading her way forward, striving to swim to the fore.

Jiu Niangzi: Finally here. So many people have joined the race ...

Jiu Niangzi: Not sure I can win.

Jiu Niangzi: But if I want to become a Xiángruì, I have to try ...

As the starting time draws closer, everyone holds their breath in anticipation, waiting for the signal to start.

Amidst the throng of burly men in coarse brown clothes, a streak of green catches the eye.

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ! Run faster, run!

Poet: Hurry up, people! Let's get this race started!

With the blast of the starting signal, the participants bolt like runaway steeds.

They go different ways. Some choose main roads, some choose alleys, and some through courtyards. Different speeds, different distances.

Jiu Niangzi: I know every street in the city, and I run fast. I just need to find the best route ...

Jiu Niangzi: *panting*

Jiu Niangzi: Faster, run faster! There's nothing faster than a Lùshǔ.

Jiu Niangzi: The purple festoon is at the butcher's on West Street, the yellow one is near the tea room in South Alley ... So the Bǎodài Bridge is the fastest way through!

Should one gaze down upon Pèi City from above, one would spy several black spots rushing forward —each a former victor of the race. Blessed with swift feet and an intimate knowledge of the city's layout, these participants are leading the pack.

In the time that it takes for an incense stick to burn, several participants are already clutching silk in their hands. They each hold a different color, grabbed from flagpoles in varying parts of the city, as each participant has taken their own route.

Jiu Niangzi: *panting*

Jiu Niangzi: Now I have the green one, too. For the blue one ... is North Street closer? No, I should go to Mr. Shěn's house.

Jiu Niangzi: Come on, Jiǔ, hurry, hurry! If you win this, you're one step closer to becoming a Xiángruì.

Half an hour has passed, and by now, everyone has moved to the main street intersection.

Here, a flagpole has been erected, atop which flutters a single red festoon. The victor's coveted prize.

Lizheng: Indeed, the red festoon should be hung on the main street. It looks more festive here.

Lizheng: I wonder who will win this year. Perhaps one of the Fǎcáo patrol team?

Facao: You're very kind to say so. The patrollers know the city well, and all of them are well-trained. They can certainly run fast.

Facao: But who knows? The city is loaded with talented people.

As they speak, a chorus of voices rises in the distance. Cheers and shouts swell like a tide, rolling down the street—a sure sign that the victor has emerged.

But it appears to be a petite figure in green that is drawing the crowd's attention. Before they can discern the details, the figure, swift as a gust of wind, is already upon them.

Facao: Looks like the winner's arrived. And they've left the others in the dust.

Facao: But I don't remember any of the patrollers wearing green today ...

Facao: Wait, that's not a patroller.

The figure lifts a foot, stepping firmly on the stone guardian by the road and leaps into the air, deftly plucking the red silk festoon from the flagpole.

In an instant, cheers fill the air—this year's champion has been decided. The crowd swarms forward. Amidst them stands Jiǔ Niángzǐ, the silk festoon clutched in her hand.

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, you did it! One, two, three ...

Ms. Xu: ... Five festoons in total! You got them all!

Eventually, the crowd splits to form a path. Lǐzhèng strides forth, his satisfaction with this unexpected outcome evident.

Following in his wake are five large sacks brimming with grain—the rightful reward for the triumphant winner.

Lizheng: As you all know, the five colored festoons represent the five kinds of grains. May the collection of the five festoons bring us a bountiful harvest for every year to come!

Lǐzhèng turns around, spreading his arms wide as he proclaims loudly to the assembled crowd.

Lizheng: Citizens, the winner this year is ... Jiǔ Niángzǐ from the tavern!

Lǐzhèng bows slightly and, following the tradition of years past, inquires about the victor's wish.

Lizheng: Tell me your wish, and I shall grant it. Anything within my power.

Lǐzhèng's mind still echoes with Jiǔ Niángzǐ's inquiry that day, her heart set on visiting the county archive to delve into matters related to the Xiángruì.

If this is her wish, a mere word to the keeper of the county archive would suffice. Lǐzhèng contemplates this privately, internally commending Jiǔ Niángzǐ's thirst for knowledge.

Jiu Niangzi: Then ...

Jiu Niangzi: My wish is ...

Jiu Niangzi: I wish for the liquor ban to be lifted.

The once bustling street now lies under a spell of silence. Not even Fǎcáo utters a word. The liquor ban is something no one would dare bring up to the officials.

The circle of onlookers first fixes their gaze upon Jiǔ Niángzǐ, then turns their attention to Lǐzhèng.

Ms. Xu: Oh dear, forgive her, Lǐzhèng. She must have run so fast that she lost her mind!

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! What are you talking about?! Just ask for a few loads of rice!

Unlike his usual prompt replies, Lǐzhèng takes some time to contemplate. Then, with a wave of his hand, he instructs Fǎcáo to hasten back to the government office.

Before long, Fǎcáo returns from the outer street, clutching a document in hand. It bears a red seal.

Lǐzhèng slowly unfurls the document, reciting each word and each sentence with great deliberation.

Lizheng: The Regulations on Liquor Sale and Consumption were issued due to the many natural disasters and food shortages of previous years, which have persisted until recent times.

Lizheng: However, due to the positive turn in the weather and the abundance of crops of late and, upon hearing Jiǔ Niángzǐ's wish, which I'm sure represents the voice of many ...

All heads crane forward, listening intently.

Lizheng: Henceforth, the liquor ban shall be lifted! Starting with the merchant hub, selling and drinking liquor will not be restricted. Other districts will follow suit in due time.

With the speech concluded, the members of the crowd look at one another in stunned silence. After a long pause, whispers begin to ripple.

The murmurs grow louder, gradually coalescing into cheers. The news travels from here to the end of the street and then throughout the entire city.

Citizen I: Really?

Citizen II: We can drink anytime we want?

Citizen III: Jiǔ Niángzǐ! Jiǔ Niángzǐ!

The crowd celebrates uproariously, as if this were the main event of the festival. The movement of the crowd squeezes Fǎcáo and Lǐzhèng onto the steps at the street's edge. Both wear smiles, observing the jubilant citizens before them.

Facao: Sorry to ask, but I don't understand what happened just now. Had you discussed this with her earlier?

Lizheng: It's not like that. It's simply a coincidence.

Lizheng: The abolishment of the liquor regulations was already on the agenda. We had planned to put up signs after the Dùshuò Festival. Jiǔ Niángzǐ's impulsive wish just so happened to align with our goals.

Lizheng: As the ancient saying goes, "there is no time like the present." Why not seize the moment and announce the news a little earlier than planned?

Facao: I see ...

Facao: Still, it takes gumption to do so.

From this day forward, the citizens of Pèi City can drink at any time.

The taverns all over the city start to see better days.

6#1

Difficult Is the Way

CH16601-07

On this day, the tavern is abuzz with extraordinary liveliness. Although the Dùshuò Festival has always been a day of celebration, the lifting of the liquor ban has made this year's festivities particularly jubilant.

The patrons have been gathered here for days on end, drinking and chatting merrily. The stock of pre-prepared liquor isn't enough to satiate them, and they have to tap into the reserves set aside long ago.

Ms. Xu: Take it easy, people! There are only so many orders I can handle!

Ms. Xu: I thought I'd prepared enough liquor, but the festival isn't even close to over, and I'm almost completely out.

Poet: I was starting to think that the liquor ban would never be lifted. Even today, I had to pinch myself to confirm it wasn't a dream!

Poet: And it's all thanks to Jiǔ Niángzǐ. Who knew that such a careless girl would speak out for the people?

Poet: She's braver than I am, that's for sure.

Jiu Niangzi: It was nothing. All I did was ask a question.

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ is always working hard to prepare and deliver liquor to everyone in the city.

Jiu Niangzi: So I thought, "What if there were no liquor ban? Then she wouldn't have to be so tired."

Old Drinker: Ah, she's starting to sound like Ms. Xǔ herself. Loving and caring—especially to us drinkers.

Old Drinker: She's learned from the best. Ms. Xǔ has been a great role model for you.

Old Drinker: Come to think of it, Lǐzhèng made a wise decision in sending Jiǔ Niángzǐ to you. He knows your personality well.

Ms. Xu: That's very sweet. Both Jiǔ Niángzǐ and I are flattered.

Old Drinker: It came from the heart. People my age never indulge in flattery.

Old Drinker: Speaking of the liquor ban ... it has actually come and gone a few times in my life.

Old Drinker: Over the years, the government has issued the ban during bad harvest years to stop people from making liquor from the grain.

Poet: I suppose there will be no need for you to sell your famous rice buns anymore. Although I must admit, I'll miss the liquor made from them.

Poet: It's the perfect thickness and has that wonderful scent of roasted rice.

Ms. Xu: Don't worry, I've taught Jiǔ Niángzǐ how to make the buns. We'll still make some now and then if there's a demand for it.

Ms. Xu: They were more of a necessity under the liquor ban; I didn't expect people to like them so much.

Ms. Xu: But the tavern will continue to get busier, so I'm afraid we might not have time to make them anymore.

The crowd is all cheering and drinking. Ms. Xǔ pulls Jiǔ Niángzǐ to one side and hands her something.

Jiu Niangzi: This is ...?

Jiu Niangzi: The picture books of monsters and Yāos! Where did you get them?

Ms. Xu: Lǐzhèng sent these to you. He knows you're interested in Xiángruì and the like.

Ms. Xu: Oh, and tomorrow is the first day of the new year. Let's go to the broken bridge together.

Ms. Xu: Some say that a giant bird has been witnessed near the bridge; it could be the Xiángruì you're always talking about. And we can pray for good luck, as others do.

Broken Bridge, Outside the City

No matter the weather, every year during the Dùshuò Festival, it always rains at the broken bridge outside the city.

The scenery on the opposite bank is shrouded in fine rain. This atmosphere, as if intentionally breeding sentiments of grief, is sure to evoke memories of the departed.

Ms. Xǔ stands with an umbrella, surrounded by pedestrians seeking good fortune on the first day of the year. They hurry by, not pausing for a moment.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, I don't see a giant bird anywhere.

Jiu Niangzi: Is there really a Xiángruì?

Jiǔ Niángzǐ tilts back her umbrella as she surveys the branches above, trying to imagine what the feathers and talons of a giant bird might look like.

Ms. Xu: It's really pouring down now. Maybe it decided to stay in the nest.

Ms. Xu: Birds don't like rainy days.

Jiu Niangzi: What a waste of time ...

Ms. Xu: A waste ...

Ms. Xu: If you have a question to ask and you find an answer, then I wouldn't say that your time's been wasted.

Ms. Xǔ leads Jiǔ Niángzǐ to the edge of the broken bridge. The remaining railings and planks have become especially bright in the rain, as if they had been broken by the flood only yesterday.

The silent passersby stop here, each holding a wooden slip in their hand.

Following suit, Ms. Xǔ takes out her own wooden slip and carefully inscribes the questions that have troubled her for many years.

Ms. Xu: In the past, if you carved your questions on a wooden slip, the Gods of Shètí would answer.

Ms. Xu: Back then, I didn't take it that seriously, so I never asked. But when I did finally have a question, the bridge was broken, and it remained unanswered.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ glances sideways and sees the words on Ms. Xǔ's wooden slip.

Jiu Niangzi: "When ... my own journey ..."

Jiu Niangzi: If no one answers, why do people keep asking?

Ms. Xu: Maybe it's because they already found their own answers. They just want divination to confirm it.

Ms. Xu: So they can finally make up their minds.

Jiu Niangzi: If you want to do something, just do it. You don't have to think that hard about it.

Jiu Niangzi: Just like the person who left me at the gate of Pèi City didn't.

Ms. Xǔ gazes at the broken bridge, falling into a prolonged silence. The rain pitter-patters on her umbrella, on the wooden railings of the bridge, and within her heart.

She ponders for a long time, unsure of how to begin ...

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ... I'm leaving here.

Ms. Xu: Leave my tavern, leave Pèi City. Follow my father and travel around the world.

Ms. Xu: It'll be a long journey. I don't know when I'll be back, so ...

At first, Jiǔ Niángzǐ cannot make sense of these words. It is as if she has been transported back to that day when she tried to read the labels on the liquor jars.

Hidden beneath her oil-paper umbrella, only the lower half of Ms Xǔ's face is visible. Her usual enthusiasm has been replaced by an almost indescribable, serene melancholy.

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Jiu Niangzi: I thought ... I thought you wouldn't leave. Not like the Daoist and my mom.

Ms. Xu: I'm sorry, Jiǔ Niángzǐ. It has always been my wish to see the greater world, to see what lies beyond Pèi City.

Ms. Xu: In fact, every time the Storyteller speaks, I cling to every word. Every night I dream of the glorious scenery and legendary characters, and I see myself there, standing among them.

Ms. Xu: When I was a young girl like you, I told my father that I would become a merchant and travel the world ... I've been stuck in Pèi City for too long—so long that I almost forgot my childhood dream.

Ms. Xu: The liquor ban was what kept me here. People needed me; they put their trust in me, so I thought it was my responsibility to run the tavern. But now, the ban has come to an end, and people can drink whenever they want.

Ms. Xu: So I told myself, "This is your chance, Xǔ. It's time to do what you want—to widen your world."

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's carelessly drops her umbrella and steps onto the broken bridge, the rain cascading down her hair. Under the bridge, the turbulent waters rush by, their destination unknown.

Jiu Niangzi: Fine. But I thought you wouldn't.

Jiu Niangzi: Since I've been here, I've been trying to find my mother—to recall what a Xiángruì is by piecing together scattered words from books and legends.

Jiu Niangzi: I thought I'd figured it out—that you were the Xiángruì I'd been looking for. So I learned from you. I tried to become a good tavern owner. Even then, I was told I was on the wrong path. But I thought, "Why not keep it this way? Nothing bad has happened. Why not live my happily-ever-after with Ms. Xǔ?"

Jiu Niangzi: But I was wrong. After all my efforts, you're still leaving me. Just like everyone else ...

Ms. Xu: I'm sorry, Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...

Jiu Niangzi: No, don't say sorry. Everyone has their own path. This is all because I followed the wrong one.

The rain grows heavier. Jiǔ Niángzǐ trudges over to the broken edge of the bridge and puts her hand on the moist handrail. She gazes over to the other side.

It seems so close, as if she could simply take a step to the other side, yet so distant, like the space she feels between herself and others.
She has never truly been close to anyone.

Jiu Niangzi: The book Lǐzhèng gave me said that the wish, any wish, of a person who jumps to the other side of this broken bridge will come true.

Jiu Niangzi: If that were me, would I be able to jump over it ...?

Ms. Xǔ swiftly steps forward and grasps Jiǔ Niángzǐ by the arm, afraid of what might come next.

Ms. Xu: No one's ever done that. Don't be silly.

Ms. Xu: That's just a story, Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Jiu Niangzi: I know it's just a story. But I took it seriously.

Ms. Xu: Jiǔ Niángzǐ ...

Ms. Xu: Go back.

The full moon hangs in the sky, illuminating the courtyard. All is still. Jiǔ Niángzǐ sits in front of a small table, a jar of fine liquor placed atop it, drinking alone.

Lifting her gaze, she sees that Ms. Xǔ's room is pitch-black. The mistress of the room has already gone to bed.

Jiu Niangzi: Back then, I used to wonder why people liked drinking liquor ...

Jiu Niangzi: It burns the throat and irritates the nose; it's not as clear as water and not as warming as tea.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ shakes her head, then lifts her liquor bowl to examine it closely. The bright reflection of the moon in her bowl resembles a jade plate or a delicate silver coin, shimmering and breaking with the movement of the liquor.

The little wooden dolls, timely as ever, clamber onto the table. They joke and giggle, adding a lively spirit to the previously peaceful courtyard.

Wooden Dolls: Alone! Alone! All alone!

Jiu Niangzi: They said liquor could take all your worries away ...

Jiu Niangzi: I didn't understand then, but now I do.

Jiu Niangzi: Alright, alright! Have a drink if you want.

Wooden Dolls: Want some! Want some!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ's eyes twinkle with joy as she brings forth a large bowl brimming with fine liquor.

The wooden dolls commence a dance on the table, then, one by one, they leap into the liquor bowl, bobbing up and down within it.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ lifts her bowl and takes a sip. Then, mimicking the patrons of the tavern, she starts humming an often-sung tune.

Jiu Niangzi: By the flowers in the snow ...

Jiu Niangzi: Raise a toast, and don't say no.

Wooden Dolls: By the flowers in the snow, raise a toast, and don't say no!

Wooden Dolls: You are having personal feelings now.

Jiu Niangzi: I'm not! I never have!
... I guess the Daoist was right. I need to become a Xiángruì, or I'll never leave Pèi City.

Jiu Niangzi: Yes, that's what I should do. To be a Xiángruì is to ...

Jiu Niangzi: To help people fulfill their wishes.

The famed tavern keeper of Pèi City, Ms. Xǔ, solemnly declares her intent to close the tavern and set off on a journey around the world. Her patrons are unanimously overcome with a wave of lamentation.

Through several days of farewell toasts, each patron of the tavern says their heartfelt goodbyes to Ms. Xǔ.

On the final day, the patrons of the city all come to bid her farewell, except for Jiǔ Niángzǐ, the serving girl, who is rumored to have already found employment elsewhere. Shortly thereafter, the tavern changes hands.

6#1

Till the Last Drop

CH166101-08

Time flies, and more than a year has passed.

Pèi City seems to have not changed at all, yet everything feels different. The bustling merchant hub is still teeming with people—an endless stream of townsfolk traveling back and forth.

Poet: Mr. Shěn, it's been a while. You seem to be in good spirits.

Poet: Would you care to have a drink?

Old Drinker: The tavern on East Street has some new arrivals.

Old Drinker: It's festival time now. Why don't we get together with some old friends?

Old Drinker: Theirs isn't as good as Ms. Xǔ's liquor, but it's good enough and has its own flavor, I suppose.

Poet: *sighs* It's so far from here. I miss Ms. Xǔ's tavern. It was closer, and the liquor tasted better.

Poet: Now it's been taken over by someone, and the liquor tastes awful.

Old Drinker shakes his head and sighs.

Old Drinker: We average folk may not drink the finest of liquor, but we're certainly able to discern a good liquor.

Old Drinker: After one sip, we can tell when the liquor is brewed carefully and when it isn't.

Old Drinker: It's such a pity that Ms. Xǔ has left the city, and there's been no news of her return since. I fear I'll never get to taste the liquor as fine as hers again.

Poet: Heh heh, personally, I miss the liquor made of rice buns more.

Poet: Since the lifting of the liquor ban, there are more taverns than ever in the city, but not one of them knows how to make those buns.

Poet: Maybe the technique is lost forever, along with Ms. Xǔ.

Old Drinker: Hmm ... I remember Ms. Xǔ mentioning that she taught it to Jiǔ Niángzǐ.

Poet: By the way, it seems no one has seen Jiǔ Niángzǐ for quite some time either.

Poet: It's all thanks to her that the liquor ban was lifted in the first place. It was she who allowed Ms. Xǔ to leave to fulfill her dream of being a merchant with no concerns.

Poet: Since that time, Jiǔ Niángzǐ's whereabouts have continued to be a mystery. Is she even still in Pèi City?

Old Drinker: Let it go, old friend. "Absence makes the heart grow fonder" and all that.

Old Drinker: There will always be a bowl of liquor waiting for us drinkers to get together over. Let's cherish this moment, eh? Come on, let's drink.

Poet: Go, go.

Poet: We better not keep it waiting. Let's go.

As they walk and talk, they turn a corner, gradually making their way down the long street toward the east and disappearing into the distance.

A figure emerges from around the corner, she had been listening to the entire conversation.

Jiu Niangzi: ...

The eavesdropper is none other than Jiǔ Niángzǐ. She has grown a touch taller than before and has shed some of her youthful naivety for a few strands of grace. Yet her every move remains as endearing as ever.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ follows the familiar path to the tavern and spots a man, the current tavern owner, standing behind the counter. There is not a single patron in the deserted front hall.

It is clear that those scenes of merriment are but a distant memory now. A thin layer of dust covers the tables and footrests, and cobwebs adorn the overhead beams. There is no trace of this tavern's former glory.

Tavern Owner: Another day and still no customers. Should I just sell this place ...?

Jiu Niangzi: Excuse me, sir, one bowl of Great Mister, please!

Jiu Niangzi: The newly made one. Scooped from the middle of the jar.

Tavern Owner: Of course. Come, take a seat.

Welcoming the tavern's first bit of business in over half a day, the tavern owner quickly taps a jar, pours a bowl of liquor, and brings it forth.

A cloudy bowl of liquor with rice dregs floating within it is presented before her. Its color is dull, and the aroma is surprisingly faint.

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm, are you sure this is Great Mister?

Jiu Niangzi: It doesn't smell like before.

Tavern Owner: The previous owner left. I brewed this using my secret formula. It tastes even better and has a lasting aftertaste.

Tavern Owner: I can't pour the liquor back into the jar, so just have a taste first. You'll see.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ hesitates for a moment, then lifts the bowl and drinks it all in one gulp.

She immediately spits the liquor back out. The taste is so awful that it is not even worth drinking.

Jiu Niangzi: Ew, it's awful. You haven't fermented it nearly long enough, and the rice you used is stale.

Jiu Niangzi: Worst of all, you didn't seal the jar after you first opened it, and the water in the air has affected the liquor.

Tavern Owner: Ah, you must be a professional taster. You're right, but this is our cheapest liquor. Our best liquor tastes totally different.

Tavern Owner: Try it. I guarantee you'll love it.

Jiu Niangzi: No need. I'm leaving.

Jiu Niangzi: Ms. Xǔ brewed every jar with her heart, no matter how cheap it was.

Her gaze grows increasingly forlorn. Finding no reason to linger any longer, Jiǔ Niángzǐ pays for the liquor and gets up to leave.

As she makes her way to the door, she hears the tavern owner behind the counter let out a sigh of lamentation, followed by a murmured monologue.

Tavern Owner: *sighs* Everyone says I'm not as good an owner as the previous one, and business is just getting worse.

Tavern Owner: I've been losing money for weeks. If something doesn't improve soon, I'll have to let someone else take over the tavern.

Tavern Owner: Or maybe I should just leave this place as soon as possible.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ stops in her tracks and, as if spellbound, promptly turns around.

The girl's eyes are filled with distress and confusion as she mumbles.

Jiu Niangzi: Leave? Like, what Ms. Xǔ did? Of course, everyone will eventually leave to fulfill another wish ...

Jiu Niangzi: And I will help them if that wish is something I can help with.

Ignoring the man's astonishment, Jiǔ Niángzǐ heads straight behind the counter and, after rummaging around for a moment, pulls out an unopened jar of liquor from a hidden compartment beneath it.

Jiu Niangzi: Amazing! You're still here! This is the fine liquor that Ms. Xǔ hid here before she left. Come, let's have a taste of it.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, I forgot. You're the owner of this jar now.

Tavern Owner: I am, but I had no idea that it was there! You must have worked here before, yes?

Tavern Owner: Go ahead. Without you, I would've had no clue that there was a jar of liquor there in the first place.

With an ease that comes from extensive practice, Jiǔ Niángzǐ breaks the clay seal, and a unique fragrance fills the room. For a moment, she can almost hear the clinking of cups and the cheerful din of patrons, as if the tavern were alive once more.

A sharp, splashing sound brings Jiǔ Niángzǐ back to reality. She looks down at the mouth of the liquor jar to see a few tiny wooden dolls swimming merrily in the brew.

Wooden Dolls: Fine liquor! Tastes great!

Jiu Niangzi: Hey, how did you—

These mischievous wooden figures have chosen this precise moment to appear. Fortunately, the tavern owner is so enraptured by the fragrance of the liquor that he remains oblivious to the oddity before him.

Tavern Owner: This scent ... This is indeed one of Ms. Xǔ's creations.

Tavern Owner: There's no way I could make liquor as fine as hers.

Jiu Niangzi: I don't think I could, either. Ms. Xǔ always selected the best rice in the grain store herself.

Jiu Niangzi: And she strictly followed the fermentation process. Even if the liquor ran out and the patrons begged her for more, she wouldn't open a new jar even a day early.

As Jiǔ Niángzǐ speaks, she blocks the man's view of the jar with her body and deftly lifts the wooden dolls out one by one, concealing them within her sleeves.

"One, two ..." she counts in her head, in silent astonishment. The last wooden doll, as if it has dissolved into the liquor itself, is nowhere to be found.

Tavern Owner: Well, it seems we were destined to meet this day.

Tavern Owner: So that I can learn what good liquor is and so you can relive past memories. Come, let's drink it together.

With this said, the tavern owner sets out two large bowls, and, after a gentle trickling of liquor, they are both filled to the brim and emitting a pleasant fragrance.

Jiu Niangzi: Wait, this is the fine liquor made by Ms. Xǔ.

Jiu Niangzi: I should use my own bowl to drink it.

Continuing her journey into the past, Jiǔ Niángzǐ heads into the back. Her former room remains unchanged, save for a few scattered items. After searching for a while, she retrieves the bowl Ms. Xǔ gifted her on that memorable day.

She returns to the front hall, only to find the tavern suddenly devoid of any human presence.

Jiu Niangzi: That's weird. Where did he go?

Jiu Niangzi: The jar is still on the counter, but one bowl has been emptied.

There is a rustling sound from behind the counter, and a striped horse timidly finds its way out into the open.

Visibly anxious, the striped horse paces around the room, its hooves clopping rhythmically.

Jiǔ Niángzǐ steps forward, caresses the horse's neck, and gently strokes its mane.

Jiu Niangzi: Where did you come from?

Jiu Niangzi: Hmm ... have I seen you somewhere before, striped horse? Did the owner just leave?

Jiu Niangzi: He did say that he wanted someone else to take over. If he has left, then I will be that someone.

Jiu Niangzi: And in doing so, I'll help him fulfill his wish.

Jiu Niangzi: That's exactly what a Xiángruì should do for people.

A figure pokes his head in the doorway.

Citizen IV: Hello, miss, is the tavern still open?

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, the tavern's not—

Jiu Niangzi: ...

Jiu Niangzi: I just took over it. Brewing takes another two weeks.

Jiu Niangzi: You can come by then.

Within a few days, the whole neighborhood has heard that the tavern owner has sold the tavern and returned to his hometown, and that the previous serving girl, Jiǔ Niángzǐ, has become the new owner.

The liquor she brews is indistinguishable from that of Ms. Xǔ's original creations, and in no time, the scattered patrons once again have a place to gather.

The tavern is bustling all day long, almost identical to how it was before.

Poet: This is the authentic Great Mister. It's the best in the city!

Poet: Jiǔ Niángzǐ, two bowls more!

Jiu Niangzi: Coming, coming!

Jiu Niangzi: Don't rush me! My hands are full!

Old Drinker: Hahaha! Feels like the old days, when Ms. Xǔ worked here alone.

Old Drinker: After you came, things finally got easier for her. And now you're the one running the tavern all by yourself.

Old Drinker: I wonder if there will be another little lady to come help you, just as you helped Ms. Xǔ.

Poet: Don't forget to make rice buns when you're not so busy!

Poet: By the way, where did that striped horse of yours go? The one that used to stay in the courtyard.

Jiu Niangzi: Oh, the horse. I have no idea. It escaped days ago. If you see it, let me know.

Jiu Niangzi: But let's not worry about that for now. It's time for a drink!

Jiǔ Niángzǐ, now the new owner of the tavern, weaves through the crowd, her eyes gleaming with joy. She skillfully attends to the guests, each cup of liquor making the crowd momentarily forget their worries.

Indeed, she follows the Daoist's words, to become a Xiángruì, to do what she should do.

In Pèi City, there are many worries waiting to be dispelled and, naturally, many wishes to be fulfilled.

On the night of the year's beginning, the main street of Pèi City is at its liveliest. Crowds throng the thoroughfare, the cries of vendors ring out, silks drape high over the streets, and piles of red pomegranates and walnuts rise in little towers on the market stalls ...

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